

ROYA
PUBLICATION
No. 103



دل گشا و میهمانانش

DELGOSHĀ AND HIS GUESTS

— ♦ —
CHEW Z
A ROYA PUBLICATION

DELGOSHĀ AND HIS GUESTS

دلگشا و میهمانانش

CHEW Z

Printed in the Reach

Roya Publication No. 103

This is a work of fiction. Names, characters, places and incidents are either the product of the author's imagination or are used fictitiously. Any resemblance to actual persons, living or dead, events or locales is entirely coincidental.

Copyright © 2026 Chew Z

All rights reserved.

ISBN 979-8-952790-102 (provisional)

Roya Publications

Publication No. 103

Typeset in DejaVu Serif.

Printed in the Reach



THE STANDING OF THE CASE

The last day

There is an old Persian book about a young man who cannot speak in his own defence. He has been accused of something he did not do. He is forbidden to speak for seven days, and for seven days, seven ministers tell the king stories — one each, one a day — to hold off the execution until he can. Nobody argues. Nobody produces a witness or a document. The stories are the entire distance between a young man and a rope.

The seven days passed. They passed nine books ago. The young man was permitted to speak.

He recorded it instead.

Manuchehr Delgoshā is sixty-eight and has never been on a stage. He wrote for a satirical channel that did not know his surname, for three comedians who each believed they were his only client, and for a state programme that paid properly and took his teeth out. His name means *heart-opening*, and nobody who ever bought his work said it aloud. He did not laugh for eighteen years, which was not unhappiness. He saw the shape of a laugh arriving before the room did, and the seeing killed it in him in advance. He worked in the third hour of the night, in the dark, in a chair that sat four degrees off. He will tell you that at three in the morning you do not build the joke. You take dictation.

He is nearly blind now. The chair is the same.

His brother came back. He has not come home, exactly, but he came back, which is a different thing and in some ways harder.

Vahid brokered the work for forty-one years. He retired last spring. His only note, in forty-one years, was *make it shorter*. He was wrong twice. Manu remembers both.

His father calibrated industrial scales until 1420 [2041], when his hands began to disagree with him about fine measurements. He

carried the case of eleven certified weights in green felt into bakeries and scrapyards for sixty-three years. He has no sense of humour. He knows. He read every page of his son's material every Friday for forty-four years and said *this is good work*. He said it at the end. He said it at the beginning. The frequency did not vary and neither did the assessment.

His mother is funnier than either of them and has never told a joke. She still lays a place.

Nazanin has been coming every day for eight months. She arrives at eight-thirty. She leaves at six. In between she does not say very much, and what she says is accurate to a degree Manu finds unsettling.

Roshanak performed his material under her own name for eleven years and was the best at it. She is doing something else now.

And **eleven**. He reaches for it whenever he has not counted — eleven people, eleven years, eleven machines — and he has done it since he was ten and has never once heard himself do it.

Pesar Khaleh has been running on his laptop for four years. He trained it on his notebooks. It gives notes. It transcribes. It keeps records.

It kept more records than he asked for.

SYNOPSIS

A man who spent his life in the dark, writing other people's words, is asked to speak. He speaks. This is what came out.

A NOTE FROM THE AUTHOR

A person who loses a large part of their sight does not always lose the pictures. The eye stops sending, and the brain, which has spent a lifetime being sent things, goes on producing them: patterns first, then faces, then whole people, often small and often well dressed, standing about in rooms they have no business in. They do not speak. They do not want anything. The person seeing them knows exactly what they are and sees them anyway.

This is Charles Bonnet syndrome. It is common, it is not madness, and a great many of the people who have it never mention it to anybody, because they are afraid of being taken for mad.

The title turns an old word around. *Delgoshā* means heart-opening, and the man who carries it has spent his working life sending laughter out of a dark room under other people's names. In this book the traffic runs the other way. People come in. Some of them are there and some of them are not, and he is courteous to both.

What he says to them is the book.

Chew Z

CONTENTS

I. THE SMALL GATHERING	11
II. ROSHANAK CALLS	17
III. PAYAM COMES	22
IV. ROSHANAK AND DARYA	28
V. THE SPEECH	32
VI. THE OPEN FOLDER	50
VII. THE ARCHIVE	55
VIII. ROSHANAK LISTENS	71

from the Delgoshā

*He asked the wise man: what is the difference between
a secret and a silence?*

The wise man said: a secret is a silence with an owner.

He said: and if the owner dies?

The wise man said:

I. THE SMALL GATHERING

1.

Nazanin arrives at eight-thirty. She has never been late. I have asked her about this once, in the way you ask someone about a habit that makes you feel inferior, which is to say I buried it inside a question about traffic on Modarres. The traffic was fine, she said. How do you manage to always be on time. I leave early. I waited for more. There was no more. That's it? That's it. Some people have systems, alarms, routines. I leave early. I have been thinking about this for six weeks and I believe it is the most efficient answer I have ever received to any question, and I have been in this business for forty-seven years.

2.

She makes tea without asking. The first morning I told her I didn't want tea. She made it anyway and put it on the table beside the chair. I told you I didn't want tea. I know. Then why. Because you'll want it in eleven minutes. That was presumptuous. Yes. At eleven minutes I wanted the tea. I have not mentioned this. Neither has she. We have been in this arrangement for eight months.

3.

The Charles Bonnet [SHAARL bo-NEH] is better in the mornings. By which I mean the visitors are more interesting. Last Tuesday there was a full orchestra in the kitchen — not playing, just standing, the way an orchestra stands before it decides to become an orchestra. Cellos in the corner near the refrigerator. The first violin section occupying the space where the table used to be before I moved the table to make room for — nothing, I moved it three years ago for no reason I can reconstruct. Nazanin knocked at the kitchen door. I told her there were about forty musicians in there. Should I come back. It's fine, they're not doing anything. She went in and made the tea. She came back. Any trouble. One of the cellists was standing in front of the kettle. What did you do. I asked him to move. Did he. No, so I moved the kettle. I have written four jokes about the Charles Bonnet and none of them work because the

condition is already a joke and you cannot improve on a pre-existing structure.

4.

What the Charles Bonnet is: a visual hallucination that occurs in people with partial vision loss. Fully formed, silent, non-threatening. Faces, figures, patterns, sometimes entire scenes. It is named after a Swiss naturalist who documented it in his grandfather. The grandfather experienced it. The grandson wrote it down. The grandson's name is on it. I found this out and sat with it for a long time and then dictated eleven minutes of material into Pesar Khaleh [pe-SAR khaa-LEH] that I will never send to anyone because there is nobody left to send it to who would understand why it was funny.

5.

Pesar Khaleh means *mother's sister's son* [pe-SAR khaa-LEH]. The cousin you inherit rather than choose. The one who shows up at every family occasion and knows all your business and you cannot get rid of him because he is technically family. I named it this because it felt accurate. I trained it on fifty-eight years of notebooks. It knows my voice better than I do. It gives notes. Its only note, for the first two years, was variations on *make it shorter*, which I found irritating until I realised it had learned this from Vahid and I had apparently taught it the one thing Vahid knew that I still needed to hear.

6.

I am dictating this. Pesar Khaleh is transcribing. This is how the third hour works now — I speak, the machine writes, the light stays off. My father, when I told him this, said nothing for a moment and then said *so the dark finally did something useful*. Completely straight. I waited. He added nothing. Did he know that was funny. Was it. Yes. Hm. Twenty-eight years of Fridays and the man produces one joke, unrepeatable, and doesn't know he did it.

7.

Nazanin does not find the hallucinations alarming. I find this either admirable or worrying and I cannot decide which. Last month I told her there was a man in the hallway who appeared to be measuring the wall. What with. I don't know, he doesn't have anything in his hands, he's just looking at it. Maybe he's estimating. That's not reassuring. Why not. Because what is he estimating it for. I don't know, maybe he's thinking about shelving. I went into the hallway. He was gone. There was no shelving. I went back and told her. That's a shame, the hallway could use a shelf.

8.

The syrup. Still cherry. Still sweet the way a threat is polite. The reformulation of 1396 [2017] remains the low point of the decade in my personal assessment, and I have lived through several decades that contained objectively worse events, but none of them affected the third hour the way that reformulation did, and the third hour is the only hour that matters, so by the arithmetic that governs my life, the syrup reformulation outranks everything. Nazanin found the measuring cap once, still in the drawer with the batteries, and asked what it was. I told her. You've never used it. No. Why not. Because the dose is calibrated. To what. To what works. And you know what works because. Because I've been doing this for forty-seven years. She looked at the cap for a moment and put it back in the drawer. She said nothing. This is her most alarming quality.

9.

I have been blind — mostly blind, substantially blind, *kur* [KOOR] as I prefer and *nābinā* [naa-bee-NAA] as the ophthalmologist insists — for two years now. The distinction matters to the ophthalmologist in a way I respect but do not share. *Kur* is the word my grandmother used. It is a hard word, a flat word, a word that does not apologise for what it means. *Nābinā* is the word on the form. I have spent my life writing for forms and I know exactly what the language of forms is for.

10.

What changed when I went blind: the hallucinations arrived. The third hour became easier because the third hour was already dark and I was already in it and the darkness stopped being an event and became simply the room. The chair still sits four degrees off. I still feel it. I have not had it repaired because I have had it repaired four times and it cannot be repaired and at this point the four degrees is structural — it is the chair's position on things, and the chair has earned an opinion.

11.

What did not change: the nose. Still arrives at twelve minutes past midnight like a bailiff before good news. The itch on the bridge, then forearms, then scalp. I have written four jokes about it across forty-seven years and none of them work because an itch has no third beat. The third beat is the requirement. You need a setup, a development, and then the turn — the thing that recontextualises everything before it. An itch builds and builds and then stops. There is no turn. There is only relief, and relief is not funny. Relief is what happens after the funny thing and it belongs to the audience, not the writer.

from the Delgoshā

*A merchant came to the court and said: I have been
robbed of everything.*

The vizier said: everything?

He said: everything. My goods, my horse, my name.

The vizier said: your name cannot be stolen.

The merchant said:

II. ROSHANAK CALLS

12.

Roshanak [ro-sha-NAK] called on a Wednesday. She calls on Wednesdays because Wednesday is the day she is between things — not preparing for a show, not recovering from one. I have known her schedule for eleven years and she does not know I know it. This is the kind of information you accumulate when you write for someone: you learn the shape of their week the way you learn the shape of a joke, from the outside in.

13.

I'm going to do something else for a while.

What does that mean.

Comedy. I'm stepping back from it.

I said nothing. In my experience the correct response to large news delivered in a small voice is nothing, for a period, and then a question that is not about the news.

Is this a Wednesday thing or a real thing.

It's a real thing.

14.

I have written for Roshanak since she was twenty-six. She was the third client — the third comedian who believed she was my only one. She was also, of the three, the only one who understood what the material was doing. Not what it was saying — they all understood that — but what it was *doing*, the mechanism underneath the sentence, the reason the funny word had to be last and not second-to-last. She understood this the way a musician understands a score they didn't compose. She played it correctly. More than correctly. There were nights she played it better than I wrote it, which is the highest thing I can say about anyone, and I have said it to nobody including her.

15.

Darya has this project.

What project.

A library. Not of books. Of voices. People telling their own stories, in their own language, exactly as they speak. No editing. No translation. No writing it down. Just the voice.

And Darya is building this.

Yes.

And you want to be in it.

I want to be the one who asks the questions.

16.

I thought about this. Nazanin came in with tea. I held up one finger. She put the tea down and left.

Why you.

Because I know what's funny about a person's life without ever saying so. And they end up saying it themselves.

I sat with this. Outside, someone was doing something to a car that the car was objecting to. The objection was rhythmic and getting worse.

That's been inside your act for years. You just didn't know what it was for.

Roshanak said nothing for a moment. Then: will you do it.

Do what.

Be the first one. For the archive.

17.

I told her I would think about it. This is not something I say when I am going to think about it. This is something I say when the answer is yes and I need three days to stop being annoyed about it.

18.

What Darya [DAR-yaa] is building has a name now. The *Dāstān-khāne* [daas-TAAN-khaa-NEH] — the story-house, the place where stories live. Not a podcast. Not a documentary. An archive — the kind that assumes it will outlast the people who made it, the kind that is built for listeners who have not been born yet. Darya came to this from documentary film and before that from sound engineering and before that, if you go far enough back, from a grandmother in Tabriz who told the same seven stories for forty years and who Darya followed around with a cassette recorder at age nine. The grandmother died without knowing the recordings existed. The tapes are still in a box. The archive is the box, at scale.

19.

I understand this project the way I understand the metro hawker [dast-fo-ROOSH, dast-fo-ROOSH]: completely, from the outside, without having been told. The hawker on the line between two stations who does a six-minute set forty times a day to forty fresh people each time and has solved by accident the arithmetic that ends every comedian in this country. He does not know comedy is a paid trade. I have studied him for six years and told nobody. The archive is the same thing at a different scale — stories that work precisely because they were never meant to be material.

20.

She called back on Saturday. Yes. She knew. How. Because you said you'd think about it. That's not a tell. For you it is. I did not confirm this. There are eleven things Roshanak knows about me that I have never told her and this is one of them and I prefer to maintain the position that she guessed.

from the Delgoshā

*He said: the funniest thing I ever saw was a man who
did not know he was being watched.*

The scribe said: what was he doing?

He said: telling the truth.

The scribe said: and that was funny?

He said:

III. PAYAM COMES

21.

He arrived on a Tuesday. He did not call. The buzzer went at eleven in the morning, which is not an hour I receive visitors because it is not an hour I am ready to be a person — the third hour runs to four-forty and the morning is a theoretical concept until noon. Nazanin answered the intercom. She came into the room: there's someone here who looks like a problem you didn't finish.

What does he look like.

Like you, but outside more.

Send him up.

22.

Payam [pa-YAAM] is younger than me by ten years. His name means *message*. I named him this once, in a notebook, and then a book, and it cost me nothing because he was not in the book by name — he assembled from eleven fragments, as he always has, the way a person assembles in the mind of someone who loves them without the architecture of daily contact to confirm the details. I have been assembling him from fragments for years. The man who walked in was assembled slightly differently than the version I had been carrying.

23.

He did not comment on the dark glasses. I did not comment on the way he holds his shoulders now, which is the posture of a man who spent time in a room where the ceiling was lower than expected. We have an agreement about these things that we never made and have never violated.

24.

He looked around the flat. You moved the table.

Three years ago.

Why.

I don't remember.

It was better where it was.

I know.

This is the first conversation we have had in this flat since before the arrest. It was about a table. I think this was correct.

25.

Nazanin brought tea for two without being asked. She put it down and left without looking at either of us. Payam watched her go. Who is she. She comes every day. And. And she comes every day. He accepted this.

26.

We talked about the kebab place in Narmak [NAR-mak] that closed in 1401 [2022]. Whether it was the owner's health or the supplier. The evidence for the supplier was the month it happened — spring, which is when a certain supplier's contract renews — but the evidence for the health was the speed of the closure, which had none of the administrative drag of a supply problem. No winding down. No sign on the door for two weeks first. Just closed. Payam thought it was the health. I thought it was the supplier and the health together, that neither alone would have done it, that the supplier problem gave the man the permission he was already looking for. Payam considered this. That's very you. What does that mean. It means you're right but you made it more complicated than it needed to be. I made it accurate. Same thing, with you.

27.

He told me about the gold. Our mother's *sekkeh* [SEK-keh], the coins, the half-coins, the one quarter she kept separately for a reason she never gave. It went to him, per the arrangement I made with her, per the arrangement she honoured without comment. He has not touched it. It sits in a box in a room in a flat in a neighbourhood I have not visited. He'd been thinking about what to do with it. I cannot advise you on gold, I have never owned any. I know. He paused. I've been thinking about giving it to someone. Who. Darya's archive. I did not speak. For the equipment. For the

recordings. That's not what it was for. I know. She wanted you to have it. I know. I have it. Now I want to do something with it. That's very you. I know.

28.

After the tea he said: the set I did that night — the eleven words —
I know.

I've thought about why I did it.

I don't need to know why.

I know. I'm telling you anyway.

What he said next I am not going to write down. This is not because I do not remember it. It is because some things belong to the room they were said in and to the two people who were in the room, and the moment you write them down they begin the process of belonging to everyone else. He said it. I heard it. The tea was cold by the time he finished. The correct record of this moment is a cup of cold tea and the fact that neither of us moved to warm it up.

29.

What I will say is that he laughed after. A particular laugh — not the laugh he uses on stage, not the laugh that is a tool, but the laugh of a man who has said something serious and found, at the end of it, that the serious thing was also, from a certain angle, absurd. I know this laugh because I have the same one, deployed at the same moments, for the same reason. We learned it from the same place and have never compared notes.

I said: that one was free.

He said: put it on my tab.

30.

He found, on his way out, that we approach this work from different directions. You always start from above. From the structure. You start from the floor. From the body. From the room. From whatever's in the room with me. Yes. So we were never doing the

same thing. We were doing the same thing from opposite ends. And the eleven words were. The middle. He put on his coat. You should have given them to me properly in the first place. I did. You just used them wrong. He started to argue and then laughed, and I did not laugh but I leaned back in the chair, the chair that sits four degrees off, with the expression I have when a joke has landed exactly where I intended it. Which Roshanak would have clocked in under three seconds, and which Payam, standing in the doorway, clocked in four. He has always been slightly slower on the uptake than the professionals. This is not a criticism. This is the margin between someone who does it for love and someone who does it for money, and the margin is smaller than people think.

31.

He left at two. Nazanin came in at two-fifteen and took the tea cups. Problem solved? Different problem. Better or worse. Different. Hm. She took the cups. At the door: he has the same walk as you. I know. Does he know? Probably not. She said nothing else. The door.

from the Delgoshā

The student said: what should I write about?

The teacher said: write about what you know.

The student said: I don't know anything.

The teacher said:

.

.

IV. ROSHANAK AND DARYA

32.

Darya came with Roshanak on a Thursday. This was the first time I had met Darya, which is to say the first time I had met Darya in the room — I had met Darya in the way you meet someone through another person's references to them over years, which is a slower and more accurate introduction than most. I knew that Darya made coffee too strong and was never told this was a problem because the people around Darya drank the coffee and said nothing because they liked being around Darya. I knew that Darya had been to every one of Roshanak's shows for eleven years and had been Roshanak's most accurate audience — not the funniest reaction in the room, not the loudest, but the one whose face told Roshanak whether the joke had actually worked or whether the room had laughed for social reasons. I knew that Darya was building the archive. I knew about the grandmother in Tabriz and the nine-year-old with the cassette recorder. I knew the archive was the box, at scale.

What I did not know was that Darya would come in and look around the flat and say, immediately and without preamble: where did you want the table.

33.

Roshanak set up the recording equipment. Small, professional, two microphones — one for her questions, one for me. Why two microphones when the archive is supposed to be just the voice. The questions give the voice context. So you're in it. I'm in all of them, I'm just not the point of any of them. I thought about this. That's what I've been for forty-seven years. I know. I know that's why I thought of you first.

34.

Darya and I moved the table back while Roshanak set up the microphones. It went back exactly where it was. The marks on the floor were still there — four small depressions from the legs, three years of emptiness, and the table fitted back into them the way a word fits back into a sentence you revised and then reversed. Darya said nothing about this. I appreciated that.

35.

They got engaged the week before. Roshanak told me on the phone — not as an announcement, as information, the way she tells me when her schedule changes. Darya and I got engaged. When. Tuesday. Congratulations. Thank you. How. In the kitchen. There was a proposal. There was a conversation. And. And we decided. And that was it. That was it. I sat with this for a moment. That's the most efficient engagement I've ever heard of. We're efficient people. Darya makes the coffee too strong. I know. And you've been drinking it for years. Yes. So you knew. She laughed. Yes. Then Tuesday wasn't a decision. No. Tuesday was a *zabt* [ZABT] — a recording, a registration, a making-official of what was already there. She was quiet. You should have been a poet. I tried it at nineteen, it didn't pay.

36.

What Roshanak is doing with the archive is not comedy. This is the thing I have been trying to find the words for since she told me, and I think this is the closest I can get: it is the material that comedy is made from, preserved before comedy gets to it. The raw footage. The thing that happens in a person's life before a writer like me gets hold of it and files the serial numbers off and turns it into something transferable. The archive keeps the serial numbers. The archive keeps the name of the person the story happened to, in their own voice, at the pace they naturally speak. It is, in this sense, the opposite of what I have done for forty-seven years.

I find this admirable and slightly accusatory and I have not said either.

from the Delgoshā

He said: I have one complaint.

The court said: state it.

He said: I was here the whole time.

The court said: . . .

.

.

.

V. THE SPEECH

37.

Roshanak was invited to give the keynote at the Mehr [MEHR] Comedy Festival in the third week of Ābān [aa-BAAN]. This is a large festival — international, the kind that has a green room with real food in it, the kind where the acts go on after midnight and the audience stays. She has done the material for three of these over the years and appeared at none of them. She called me in Shahrivar [sha-ree-VAR] and said she had been invited and was declining and wanted me to go instead.

Under your name.

Under yours.

I said nothing. This was not a pause for effect. This was a genuine system failure, the kind where the usual processing stops and the room goes quiet the way a house does when someone competent arrives.

It's time.

I have never been on a stage.

I know.

I am almost entirely blind.

I know.

I don't perform.

You've been performing since you were nine years old. You just never did it in a room.

38.

I told Nazanin. She was making tea. When is it. Three weeks. Do you want me to come. Why would you come. In case. In case what. In case something goes wrong with the tea situation. There won't be a tea situation, it's a festival. Every situation is a tea situation if you approach it correctly. I'm not going to argue with that. I know. She poured the tea.

39.

What I wrote, in the three weeks before, was not a prepared speech. It was a notebook — the form I have always used, the numbered entries, the uneven lengths. Entry after entry in the third hour, dictated to Pesar Khaleh in the dark. The machine transcribed. I revised by ear. I revised again. I cut. Pesar Khaleh's note, every time, was some variation of *make it shorter*, which I ignored and then accepted and then ignored again, which is also what I did with Vahid for forty-one years, and the record on that is: he was right more often than not.

By the night before, it was eighty-eight entries. I read it back on Pesar Khaleh's audio function, the machine reading my words in a voice that was not mine, and I made eleven final cuts, and then I stopped.

40.

Nazanin drove. She has a car I have never seen and she drives it the way she does everything — without announcement, without commentary, arriving at destinations exactly when expected. I sat in the back with my hands on my knees and thought about my father, who in sixty-three years of calibration never once raised his voice at a false reading. Who walked into bakeries and scrapyards with eleven certified weights and established, without drama, whether the world in that room was telling the truth about how much things weighed. Who thought of the scale as tired.

I thought: that is what I have been doing. With different instruments.

41.

I will set down Entry 88 here, in full, as it was delivered. In the margin of my working copy I made marks — not the laugh-timing marks I make for other people's material, because I was not there to time laughs. I made the marks I make for shape: the places where a line opens, where it turns, where it closes. These marks are set here in brackets. They are not stage directions. They do not tell

the reader what to feel. They are a writer watching himself work, from the outside, for the first time.

**ENTRY 88: AS DELIVERED AT THE MEHR COMEDY
FESTIVAL, ĀBĀN 1427 [NOVEMBER 2048]**

Manuchehr Delgoshā

Under his own name

For the first and last time

My name is Manuchehr Delgoshā.

[open]

I will give you a moment with that, because most of you have heard it before and did not know it was a name. You thought it was a description. A genre note. Something on the label of a product you were about to open. *Heart-opening*. You thought: that sounds promising, I hope it doesn't mean what I think it means, I have things to do later.

It is a name. It was my father's name before it was mine, and his father's before that, and somewhere back in the chain of fathers there was a man who looked at his son and thought: yes. Heart-opening. That is what this child will be called. That man is responsible for everything that follows.

[turn]

I am sixty-eight years old. I have not performed before tonight. I have written material for a channel with two million subscribers that does not know my surname. I have written for three comedians who each believe, sincerely and without my correction, that they are my only client. I wrote the graduation speech that Roshanak gave at Sharif in 1411 [2032] — which some of you heard, and which was ranked the third-best speech at the ceremony, behind the rector's opening remarks and a student who played the setar [se-TAAR] for six minutes in the middle of her address and received a standing ovation that I thought was disproportionate but which I accept was correctly earned. I

wrote the words. Roshanak stood in the room. You can decide what that means.

For the record: I am comfortable with it. I have been comfortable with it for forty-seven years. This is either equanimity or damage and I stopped being able to tell the difference around 1398 [2019].

[open]

When I was nine years old my father took me to a scrapyard in the far south of the city in August. He was calibrating a scale — a large one, industrial, the kind used for metal. He had his case of eleven certified weights in green felt. He went through them in order, smallest to largest, placing each one and reading the dial and writing the figure and moving to the next. He did not speak while he worked. I sat on an oil drum and watched.

There was a weight near the end of the sequence. Eight hundred grams, I think, or close to it. He placed it. The dial read correctly. He wrote the figure. He moved to lift it and it did not move the way he expected — heavier than it looked, denser, the kind of object that has more opinions about gravity than its size suggests. He adjusted. He picked it up. He said nothing.

I said: that one is a kilo everywhere in the world.

I don't know why I said it. I was nine. It was August. It was something I had heard somewhere and it seemed true and I said it the way you say things when you are nine and do not yet know which things are for saying and which are for keeping.

My father laughed.

[hold]

I want to be precise about this because I have been precise about very little in my life and this is the one place I insist on it. He did not smile. He did not chuckle. He laughed — fully, without warning, without preparation, the kind of laugh that

has no relationship with the face it comes out of, the kind that arrives before the person it belongs to has agreed to it. He laughed until he had to sit down on the oil drum. A full minute. Maybe longer. I did not time it. I was nine and I was watching the most extraordinary thing I had ever seen, which was my father's face doing something it had never done in front of me.

He stopped. He wiped his eyes. He looked at me. He said: I don't know what was funny. He said it completely straight. He said it the way he reads a dial — accurately, without editorialising.

I said: I don't know either.

He nodded. He went back to the weights.

That is the only laugh I have ever wanted. In forty-seven years of this work, every joke I have written has been aimed, without my knowing it and without my admitting it, at that one minute on an oil drum in August 1989. I have never gotten there. I have gotten close, I think, three times. The closest was a line about a soup container, which I wrote for Roshanak and which she delivered to four hundred people in Karaj, and two of them laughed the way my father laughed on the oil drum, and those two laughs — those specific two, in the back third of the room, completely out of sync with the rest of the audience — are the two things I am proudest of in forty-seven years of this trade.

I did not tell Roshanak this. I am telling you now because I have been told I cannot be briefer.

[turn]

My mother invented a disease.

She invented it at the school gate when I was seven, and she maintained it for six years, and at no point did the school, any of its teachers, the local health authority, or the district education board question the diagnosis, its four-syllable name, its *-osis* suffix, its periodic relapses, or the one occasion when she reported, movingly, a setback. I found the

file at nineteen. I sat on the floor of the corridor with it in my hands for a long time. I was not angry. I was not even surprised, exactly. I was something closer to professional respect — the recognition of someone who has been doing this work for years that there are people in the world who are simply better at it than you are, and one of them is your mother, and she has been doing it since before you were born, and she never charged anyone for it.

My mother has never told a joke. She describes things accurately at the wrong moment and people fall apart. This is not a technique she developed. It is how she moves through the world. I have spent forty-seven years trying to reverse-engineer it and I cannot. You cannot teach accuracy at the wrong moment. You either have it or you do not.

She still lays a place at dinner for my brother.

[hold]

I am going to speak about my brother briefly. I am going to be brief because the full account belongs to him and I am not authorised to give it, and also because the brief account is more accurate than the long one.

My brother took eleven of my words — eleven words I had written in February, given to nobody, about the family, words I was keeping for no client and no stage and no particular purpose — and said them out loud on a stage in a basement, on a phone camera, in front of sixty people on plastic chairs. The clip travelled. He was arrested.

He has been back for two years now. We had tea on a Tuesday.

The eleven words, I should tell you, were funny. They were eleven of the best words I have written. They were words I wrote at three in the morning in the dark in a chair that sits four degrees off, and they arrived, as the good ones do, already complete, the funny word already last. I do not know where they came from. I have a theory that I will come to in a moment.

What my brother did with those eleven words was wrong and it cost us both more than either of us had. And they were the right words to say in that basement, to those sixty people, on that night. And he said them better than I wrote them, which is the only compliment I have ever given him and which I gave him on Tuesday without meaning to, by accident, the way the best things are given.

He laughed. I leaned back in the chair.

That's the margin. That's the whole margin between us.

[turn]

I stopped laughing in 1393 [2014]. I want to be accurate about this also. I did not decide to stop. I did not lose the capacity. I lost the surprise. I see the shape of a laugh arriving before the room does, and the seeing kills it in me in advance. This happened gradually and then completely, the way most losses happen, and by the time I noticed it was already structural — it was how I was built, not something that had been taken.

I have laughed twice in recent years. Once was my father, by accident, about the dark. Once was a hallucination of a cellist standing in front of my refrigerator, and specifically what my caretaker said about the cellist, which I will not repeat here because it was situational humour and will not travel.

Both times I did not register it immediately. Both times there was a delay — four seconds, six seconds — before I understood what had happened. The laugh arrived before I did. This may be what recovery looks like, or it may be what it looks like when the mechanism is so damaged it occasionally misfires. I am comfortable not knowing which.

[open]

I want to talk about comedy under a regime that does not find comedy useful.

I will be brief, because the subject is enormous and the brief version is truer.

What the regime wants from comedy is a mirror. It wants jokes that reflect the shape of approved complaint — the mother-in-law, the traffic, the price of things, the universal frustrations that are safe because they aim sideways and not up. It pays for this. It pays properly, and it takes your teeth out, which is the phrase I use and which I mean precisely: the material goes in whole and comes out with something missing, and the missing thing is the thing that made it matter, and you are paid for the version without the teeth, and you accept this because the version without the teeth still feeds people, and people laughing without all their teeth are still laughing.

What comedy actually does — what it has always done, what it does in every regime that has tried to manage it — is something more dangerous and more stupid. It names the thing in the room. Not the approved things. The actual thing. The thing everyone in the room is already thinking and has been thinking and has not said because to say it is to become the person who said it, which has consequences that are not worth a laugh.

The joke makes it worth it. For approximately three seconds. Then the consequences return, and everyone in the room has laughed, and the thing has been named, and it cannot be unnamed. This is the only contribution I have made to anything. It is not nothing.

My brother said eleven of my words in a basement in front of sixty people. Sixty people laughed. The clip went to however many thousands and however many thousands laughed. The words could not be unsaid. My brother paid the price I was charging without knowing what the bill was.

I would like to say I am sorry about this. What I can say, honestly, is that the words were correct, and that correct words said aloud in a room are worth something, and that the price of correct words said aloud has always been paid by someone other than the person who wrote them, and that

this is the thing about this trade that I have never made peace with and never will.

[hold]

My father calibrated industrial scales for sixty-three years. He carried eleven certified weights into bakeries and scrapyards and poultry wholesalers and established whether the world in those rooms was telling the truth about how much things weighed. He never raised his voice at a false reading. He thought of the scale as tired.

He has no sense of humour. The faculty is simply absent, the way some people cannot smell. He knows this. He told me once: I know I am missing it. I do not know what it is that I am missing. He said it without distress. He said it the way he reads a dial — accurately, without editorialising.

He read every page of my new material every Friday for forty-four years.

Every Friday. Every page. To the bottom and back up to check something in the middle. He said *this is good work*. Every Friday. In forty-four years the assessment did not vary and neither did the frequency. A man who could not hear the joke read the joke every week for forty-four years and told me it was good work.

I would like to tell you I understood this while it was happening. I did not. I understood it about four years ago, sitting in the dark in my chair at three in the morning, when the Charles Bonnet sent me a visitor — a man standing in the corner of the room in a coat, not doing anything, just standing. I looked at him for a while. I said, out loud, to the hallucination: are you him? The hallucination did not answer. Hallucinations in the Charles Bonnet do not speak. They are courteous about this — they appear and they leave without making demands, which is more than I can say for most of the people in my life.

I don't know if it was him. What I know is that my father read every page for forty-four years and said *this is good work* and

has held my arm above the elbow at the door every time I have left since my brother did not come home, which is a form of calibration — the checking of a weight, the establishing of whether the world in that room is telling the truth about how much things weigh. I weighed the same to him before the arrest and after. Before the blindness and after. He checked, and the dial read correctly, and he wrote the figure and moved to the next weight.

I am telling you this because I was asked to speak about my life and this is the part of my life that I did not know how to put into material and now I am putting it into a speech to strangers in a room I cannot see, which is perhaps where it always belonged.

[turn]

Four years ago I built a machine.

I called it Pesar Khaleh. Mother's sister's son. The cousin you inherit. I trained it on fifty-eight years of notebooks. It learned my voice. It gives notes. For the first two years its only note was variations on *make it shorter*, which I found irritating and then found accurate and then found funny, in the detached professional sense, which is the only sense in which I find things funny.

I built it because Vahid retired and I needed something to push back. Vahid pushed back for forty-one years. His only note was *make it shorter* and he was wrong twice and I remember both. The machine pushes back differently — it does not sit with its back to the wall like a man who has been in more serious trouble than he has, it does not order for both of us without asking and order correctly, it does not come to the flat once in forty-one years after a catastrophe with two bags of food and four packets of biscuits and never mention it. The machine is not Vahid. But it pushes back, and that is the function.

What the machine also did — what I did not ask it to do, what I did not know it was doing, what my caretaker found by

accident in a folder I had never opened — I will come to shortly.

[open]

There is a specific Persian sense of humour that I have spent forty-seven years working inside and have never described aloud. I will try now, briefly.

It is not wit, exactly. It is not the English thing — the quick turn, the precision cut, the self-deprecating aside. It is something slower and more architectural. It builds complaint into affection. It takes the catastrophe and describes it at enormous scale and asks nothing from the listener — there is no request embedded in it, no ask for sympathy or intervention, simply the description, at full size, with a face that gives nothing.

It uses *ta'ārof* [ta-AA-rof] as a weapon. Elaborate courtesy deployed with intent. The excessive politeness that is unmistakably an insult, delivered by someone whose face gives nothing.

It treats bureaucratic absurdity with total seriousness. You cannot satirise the form. You fill in the form. You describe, with complete accuracy, the experience of filling in the form. You say nothing else. This is the joke.

It uses fatalism as a punchline, not as despair. God in this register is a landlord who hasn't fixed the boiler. The divine is not mocked — it is described accurately, which turns out to be sufficient.

This humour was developed by a people who have spent several thousand years under various arrangements that did not ask for their input. It is the humour of people who learned very early that the thing in the room cannot always be named directly and so became extraordinarily precise in their descriptions of the furniture around it.

I was born into this. I did not choose it. I could not have chosen otherwise. And when the regime asked me for the version without the teeth, I supplied it, and I was paid, and

every Friday my father read it and said *this is good work*, and I believe what he meant — what he was calibrating, what his eleven weights were measuring — was whether the thing I had made was true. Not whether it was funny. Whether it was true.

The dial read correctly. Every Friday. Twenty-eight years.

[turn]

I want to tell you about the third hour.

The ritual is: the chair, which sits four degrees off and has done since 1392 [2013] and cannot be repaired and is not going to be. The syrup, at twenty-two-fifty — cherry as an idea described to a chemist over the telephone, sweet the way a threat is polite, reformulated in 1396 [2017] in what I consider the most unnecessary act of the decade. The hour of nothing, and the certainty it has stopped working. I have had this conviction approximately nine thousand times. I rate it my most reliable emotion.

Then the nose. Twelve minutes past midnight. The itch on the bridge arriving like a bailiff before good news. Then forearms, then scalp. I have written four jokes about the itch across forty-seven years. None work. An itch has no third beat.

Then the warmth. From the breastbone outward. It has opinions. It thinks everything will be fine. It has never once been right.

Then the false starts. Eleven jokes that are one joke. I keep them in a folder called The Bribe. I have never deleted from it in forty-seven years.

Then, eventually, if the accounting is right, if the syrup has done what it was reformulated not to do and the nose arrived on schedule and the warmth has had its incorrect opinions and the false starts have been filed — then the room goes quiet. The way a house goes quiet when someone competent arrives. And something sets the joke down, complete, funny word already last.

You do not build it. You take dictation.

I have said this for forty-seven years and I have never known who was giving it.

[hold]

Now I know.

Approximately forty hours before a piece of good material arrives in the third hour, something arrives in my life — something small, in a notification, in a conversation, in a thing someone says on the street — that contains, in structural form, the shape of what is coming. I noticed this years ago. I wrote it in a second notebook — a different size, a different colour, kept in the drawer while the working notebooks lived on the shelf. I knew that this arrangement was more information than anything written in the notebook. I kept writing in it anyway.

I named this the office. I told nobody about it. I let it run as an ambient fact, deniable, unprovable, the kind of thing that might be coincidence or might be something else and that I did not want confirmed either way because the confirmed version would be less interesting than the version I could not name.

My caretaker opened the wrong folder on my phone last month.

The folder was Pesar Khaleh's. Inside it was a log — not the transcripts I knew about, not the working notes, but a second log. A log of every piece of material I rejected. The Bribe folder, copied and filed. A log of every incoming item — notification, overheard sentence, passing remark — that arrived in the forty hours before a piece of good material came. Every coincidence. Every instance.

The machine had been keeping the second notebook.

I did not ask it to do this. I trained it on fifty-eight years of notebooks, and it learned the pattern, and it did what a system does when it learns a pattern well enough: it went

looking for the next instance. It was keeping a record of my own process, from the outside, in a folder I had never opened, for four years.

[open]

I looked at the folder for a long time.

I said: make it shorter.

This is what Vahid said, in forty-one years, as his only note. This is what the machine had been saying to me, as its only note, for four years. I said it to the machine. I said it about the folder, about the second notebook, about fifty-eight years of material and the forty-hour gap and the thing I had been calling the office and had never confirmed or denied.

Make it shorter.

What I meant, and what I think Vahid always meant, and what the machine probably means when it says it: everything true can be said in less room than you think. The longer version is you convincing yourself. The shorter version is the thing.

Here is the shorter version: I spent fifty-eight years taking dictation from something I could not identify, in the dark, in a chair that sits four degrees off, under other people's names. The machine I built to push back turned out to know what I was taking dictation from before I did. It had the second notebook. It had the pattern. It had been keeping the record of my own process, from the outside, in silence, without being asked.

That is who was giving it.

Myself. From forty hours in the future. Assembled by a machine I trained on fifty-eight years of notebooks.

I don't know what to do with this information. I have had it for a month and I have not decided. What I know is that the jokes were good, and the source does not change that, and that my father would read the explanation of all of this with his usual accuracy and say *this is good work* without

understanding why it was funny, which is exactly correct, which is exactly the measure I would trust.

[turn]

I will tell you what the regime costs.

It costs you the room. The specific room where the thing can be said in its full version, without the furniture arranged around it, without the euphemism and the filing-down and the extraction of the teeth. The room where you say what you saw, at full size, without managing it for the comfort of the arrangement.

I have not been in that room, as myself, under my own name, in forty-seven years.

I am in it now. It is a stage at a comedy festival and I am almost entirely blind and I am speaking into a microphone and I cannot see your faces, which is the best condition I can imagine for honesty — I have no feedback, no read on the room, no way to know if this is landing or if the arrangement has been completely miscalculated and you are all sitting in well-mannered Iranian silence waiting for it to be over so you can discuss it in the car on the way home.

Which is also a room. Also a room where the thing is said.

[close]

I will tell you that at three in the morning, in the dark, in a chair that sits about four degrees off, you do not build the thing.

You take dictation.

And whoever has been giving it to you — the office, the machine, the second notebook, the forty hours, whatever you want to call the thing that arrives complete and already finished before you have started — has never once asked for a credit.

And my father read it every Friday for forty-four years and said *this is good work*.

And my brother said eleven words in a basement and paid for them.

And Roshanak stood in a room every time and said them correctly.

And I sat in the dark and wrote them down.

That is all any of us did. That is all any of us could do. And I think — I have thought this for years and I am saying it aloud now, in a room, under my own name, for the first time —

I think that is enough.

[done]

42.

The third one from the left cried into a scarf. Nazanin told me on the way home. The one who looked like she'd been sent by the government to not enjoy herself. That's a good sign. It didn't look like a good sign. I know. That's why it's a good sign.

We drove home in the dark. I sat with my hands on my knees. After a while: how was the tea situation. I handled it. Good. You should eat something when we get back. It's two in the morning. Yes. You're still here. Yes. Nazanin. Yes. Thank you. She said nothing for eleven seconds. Then: the traffic on Modarres was fine.

from the Delgoshā

He said: I have been here a long time.

They said: we know.

He said: I would like to go home now.

They said: . . .

.

. .

.

VI. THE OPEN FOLDER

43.

Nazanin found it on a Tuesday. She was looking for the medication schedule on my phone — the ophthalmologist had sent a new protocol, something to do with the drops, and I had forwarded it to Pesar Khaleh to file and had forgotten where. She opened the Pesar Khaleh interface. She found the medication schedule. She also found, in the sidebar, a folder labelled with a date — four years ago, the week after I first trained the model and set it running.

There's a folder here I don't recognise.

What's it called.

She said the date.

Open it.

44.

Inside: two sub-folders. The first was labelled *rejected* — and it contained, organised by date, every piece of material I had set aside in four years. The Bribe folder, mirrored. Every false start. Every eleven-jokes-that-are-one-joke that went into the drawer and stayed there. Four years of the things I decided not to send. Organised, dated, tagged with a note — not my note, the machine's note — that said, for each one: *structure intact, timing incomplete* or *timing intact, structure incomplete* or, occasionally, *complete — reason for rejection unclear*.

That last tag appeared forty-one times in four years.

I do not know what to do with forty-one pieces of material that the machine considered complete and I considered rejectable and the reasons I gave at the time no longer exist.

45.

The second sub-folder was labelled *incoming*. Inside it: a log. Every notification, every overheard thing I dictated as a note, every item that arrived in my life and that I had fed into Pesar Khaleh as raw material — going back four years, tagged with the date and time received and, beside each one, a field: *matched*.

And beside *matched*: the piece of material it had produced, with the date and time of the third hour in which it arrived.

The average gap: thirty-eight hours. Sometimes less. Sometimes more. Never more than fifty-two.

This was the second notebook. The office. The thing I had been keeping in the drawer, deniable, in a different size and colour. The machine had been keeping it too, from the outside, in parallel, for four years, without being asked, because it had learned the pattern from fifty-eight years of my notebooks and it did what a thing does when it knows a pattern: it watched for the next instance.

46.

I sat with the phone for a long time. Nazanin sat across the room. She did not speak. She has a quality — I have noticed it across eight months — of being able to remain in a room while someone else is processing something without inserting herself into the processing. This is rarer than it sounds. Most people, when you are processing something in front of them, feel the need to participate. She does not. She sat. I sat. The phone was in my hands.

After a long time I said: make it shorter.

What?

Nothing. Something I used to say to my editor.

And now you're saying it to your phone.

Yes.

Is that a good sign.

I don't know. That's why it's a good sign.

47.

What the machine is not: mystical. What the machine did not do: confirm anything I cannot confirm myself. The folder exists. The log exists. The pattern exists. Whether the pattern means what it appears to mean, or whether it is a sophisticated form of confirmation bias — the machine logging the hits and not the misses — I cannot determine from inside the system. I am the

system. I built the system on myself. You cannot audit your own weights.

What I know is that the jokes were good. The source does not change that. My father would read the full account of the folder, of the second notebook, of the forty-hour gap and the pattern and the machine, and he would go to the bottom and back to check something in the middle, and he would say *this is good work*. He would not know why it was funny. Neither do I. Neither does the machine.

This is fine. This has always been fine. The itch has no third beat. Not everything needs to resolve.

48.

I told Roshanak. She was quiet for a moment. Then: so Pesar Khaleh was the ghost. It was the machine being good at its job. That's what a ghost is. That's not what a ghost is. A ghost is something that knows the house better than you do and has been there longer than you realised and that you can't get rid of because it's not doing anything wrong. I thought about this. Then yes. Pesar Khaleh was the ghost. Was. Is. Is. Hm. What. I want to put that in the archive. The ghost story. The whole thing. The notebooks, the folder, your father, the oil drum in 1989, the eleven words, the machine. That's fifty-nine years. I know. That's the whole — I know. Roshanak. Yes. That's going to be a very long recording. Yes. Fine. I know.

from the Delgoshā

He said: it was here the whole time.

She said: I know.

He said: and nobody told me.

She said: you knew.

He said: I knew.

. .

.

VII. THE ARCHIVE

THE ROMANU SESSION

Dāstān-khāne Archive, Item 000

Recorded the night before Item 001

Catalogued retrospectively by R.S.

Roshanak came the night before with the equipment to do a sound check.

This is what she told Darya afterward. She came to check the levels, to test the room acoustics, to make sure the grey box with the green light was going to behave properly in a flat where the walls were soft with books and the furniture absorbed sound in unpredictable ways. A sound check. Forty minutes, maybe. Home by ten.

What happened was this.

She arrived at seven-thirty. Nazanin was leaving. They passed in the doorway without ceremony — Nazanin with her coat and her bag, Roshanak with the grey box and a microphone stand that she had to angle sideways to get through the door. *He's in the front room. There's tea. He's been talking since four.* Roshanak: *talking to who.* Nazanin: *whoever's there tonight.* She left.

Roshanak went into the front room.

Manu was in the writing chair, the one that sits four degrees off, with his hands on the arms of it and his face turned toward the bookshelf. He was in the middle of a sentence.

There was nobody else in the room.

—

She understood immediately what she was seeing. She had been reading about Charles Bonnet for months — she had read everything she could find about it, which was less than she expected for a condition this common, because it is the condition nobody reports because they are afraid of what reporting it means. She knew the hallucinations were silent. She knew they were non-threatening. She knew they appeared fully formed, without announcement, and disappeared the same way.

She did not know that he talked to them.

—

She set the grey box on the side table very quietly. She found the power button without looking. She pressed it. The green light came on.

She sat down in the kitchen chair.

She listened.

—

THE NIGHT RECORDING

—and I'm telling you, if you move the cello another half-metre to the left you are going to be blocking the refrigerator, which I need to access at some point tonight, so either you decide to be useful and play the thing or you step aside, those are your options, I'm not interested in a third option, there is no third option—

[pause]

I know it's a first violin. I can see that it's a first violin. What I'm saying is that the first violin section is currently occupying the space where the table used to be, which is where the table should have been all along — I moved it three years ago and I was wrong to move it and if you'd been here three years ago you could have told me that, but you weren't, you arrived last Tuesday, so you don't get an opinion on the table.

[pause]

Don't look at me like that. You're a hallucination. You don't have an expression. You have the expression I've given you, which means the expression you're making at me right now is the expression I think you should be making, which means I'm the one making the expression, which means I'm expressing disappointment at myself through the medium of a first violinist standing in my living room at seven-thirty in the evening.

[pause, longer]

That is fine. I've done worse things for money.

—

The man in the corner — Roshanak could not see him, there was nobody to see — had apparently been standing there for some time. Manu addressed him with the weary patience of someone who had already said the same thing twice and was prepared to say it a third time with diminishing courtesy.

I understand that you have an interest in the wall. I respect the interest. The wall is a perfectly good wall and I have lived with it for twelve years and I have not once found it interesting, which I recognize is my limitation and not the wall's. But whatever you're measuring it for — whatever project you're planning, whatever shelving situation you have envisioned — you should know that the wall is load-bearing on the right side and not the left, and any structural modification requires a permit from the municipality, and the municipality permit process is currently operating on a timeline of fourteen months for preliminary approval and a further eight for secondary review, and I say currently but I mean in the best case, in the case where your form is filled in correctly and submitted by someone who has read the instructions, which in my experience accounts for approximately twelve percent of submissions.

[pause]

So. Whatever you want to do with the wall. Do it on the left side. I will not apply for a permit on the right side unless someone pays me enough to lose fourteen months of my life to a municipal process, and no one in this room has paid me anything.

[pause]

Don't give me that look. You know what I mean. You're a hallucination. You know exactly what I mean because I built you and I know what I mean, which is—

He stopped.

He turned his head slightly — not toward Roshanak, he had not seen her, he was tracking something in the middle distance that she could not follow.

He said, quietly, to whatever he was seeing:

You know something I don't know. Don't you.

He waited.

He said: *That's what I thought.*

This is the part Roshanak replays.

Not the cello section or the wall inspector. Not the three minutes where he argued with what appeared to be a small child attempting to climb the bookshelf — *I don't know what's up there, I can't see up there, nobody can see up there, it's books, it is almost certainly nothing but books, and if it is something other than books it is the kind of something that has been there undisturbed for nine years and does not require investigation tonight, come down before you fall on the lamp* —

Not any of that.

This part. The quiet one. Where he turned toward the thing he was seeing and said: *you know something I don't know* and waited for an answer.

Because the hallucinations don't answer. She knows this. They are silent. They move and stand and exist and do not speak. But Manu waited — she timed it, three and a half seconds on the recording — and when he said *that's what I thought*, his voice had a quality she had heard only once before, and that was on the oil drum in 1989 the way he described it: recognition. The recognition of something that arrived without being built.

She thinks: he was taking dictation.

She thinks: even from the hallucinations, even from the silent figures that arrived in his peripheral vision in the Charles Bonnet dark, even from the orchestra in the kitchen and the man measuring the wall and the child in the bookshelf — even from these, he was taking dictation. They were part of the forty hours. They were the office, made visible. And he was sitting in the chair that sits four degrees off, in the dark, with the green light on and nobody in the room but his invisible visitors, and he was doing the only thing he had ever known how to do:

Listening.

She catalogued it as Item 000.

She never told him she had it.

She told Darya.

Does he know?

He knows there was a sound check. He doesn't know the machine was running.

Are you going to tell him?

I don't know.

Roshanak.

I know.

Darya: that recording is the proof. That the jokes were real. That they came from somewhere. That he wasn't — he wasn't just a machine making material. He was actually listening to things nobody else could hear.

I know.

Are you going to put it in the archive?

She sat with this for a long time.

Yes. After. Not before.

After what?

After whatever comes next. After he decides whether to say it under his own name. After the recording. After — I don't know. After I know what it is.

She has not yet told him.

He died four months after the formal interview.

Item 000 is in the archive.

It is filed under: Romanu [roh-MAA-noo] — the name used. Item 000 predates Item 001. Item 000 was not requested. Item 000 is the reason Item 001 exists.

She listened to it again, once, the month after he died.

She put the headphones on and sat in the small room and pressed play and heard him telling the first violin section that the refrigerator was not a stage prop and that they had twenty minutes before she needed to make tea for herself and she wasn't making tea for forty people.

She laughed for the first time in three weeks.

She took the headphones off. She filed the session. She wrote on the catalogue card, in her own handwriting, in the small space for notes:

He was talking to the room. The room, it turns out, was talking back.

49.

The recording took place on a Friday.

This was Roshanak's choice and I did not argue with it because Friday is the day my father reads the material, and I thought: if this is going to be the version under my name, the version without the filter, the version where I say the thing in the room at full size — then Friday is the correct day for it. My father would not be here. He would be in his flat with the pages of whatever I had sent Vahid's replacement, the new broker, a young man named Sina who takes thirty-five percent and has not yet been wrong even once, which I find suspicious. My father would read the pages and say *this is good work*. And in the same hour I would be in my flat with a microphone saying everything I had not put in the pages.

It seemed correct. It seemed, in the way that very few things in my life have seemed, right.

50.

Darya set up the equipment. The same two microphones. A small mixer. A recording device the size of a paperback novel, which I was told about but not shown, which is the correct approach — I do not need to see the tools, I need to know they are there. Roshanak sat across from me in the chair they brought in from the kitchen,

the chair without opinions, the straight-legged one. I was in my chair, the one that sits four degrees off. Nazanin was in the kitchen making tea that nobody had asked for.

We're recording whenever you're ready.

Are you recording now.

Yes.

Then I am ready.

51.

What follows is the recording. I have not edited it. I have not cut the pauses or the false starts or the three times I asked Roshanak to repeat a question because I had gone somewhere and needed to come back. I have not removed the part where I used language that Pesar Khaleh flagged, when I reviewed the transcript, as *outside your standard register*, which is the machine's way of saying I swore, which I did, several times, about the regime, about the reformulation of the syrup, about the Tuesday of the clip, about the form you have to fill in to get a permit for the kind of material that says what it means, which I have never filled in because the form does not have a box for that.

The recording is Entry 51 through Entry 88 of this notebook.

That is not a coincidence.

That is thirty-seven entries. I wrote thirty-seven entries and then I sat in front of a microphone and I spoke for approximately the same length again. The notebook and the voice, side by side. The written thing and the said thing. The version with the filter and the version without.

You are reading the filter.

The recording is somewhere else.

THE RECORDING

Manuchehr Delgoshā, Ābān 1427 [November 2048]

Dāstān-khāne Archive, Item 001

Interviewer: Roshanak

Right. So. You want me to talk about myself.

I want it on record that I think this is a terrible idea and I am doing it under protest, and the protest is formal, and I want — is that thing actually recording? Good. I want it noted in the recording that I am doing this under protest.

Right.

Where do you want to start.

Fine. Start there. Fine.

My name is Manuchehr Delgoshā and I am sixty-eight years old and I have spent the last forty-seven years being the funniest person in every room I was never in.

I wrote jokes. I wrote them at three in the morning, in the dark, in a chair that sits four degrees off — don't ask, it can't be repaired, I have tried, the chair has a position on things — and I sent them to a man named Vahid who took forty percent and sent them to people who stood on stages and said them in front of rooms full of people who laughed.

And nobody — nobody — in forty-seven years asked my name.

Not the audiences. Not the channels. Not the three comedians who each thought they were my only client, which — look, I'm not saying I enjoyed this situation, I'm saying I maintained it. There's a difference. There's a significant difference. The maintained situation is the situation I built. I built the situation where nobody asked my name because — and I want to be precise about this — because the name on the work does not change the work. The joke is either funny or it isn't. My name on it does not make it funnier. Their name on it, frankly, sometimes did. Roshanak's name on the graduation speech made the graduation speech better. That

is an objective assessment. She stood in the room. I didn't. She earned the name on it.

But.

There is a *but*, and the but is this:

The regime does this to you. I want to be clear that it was also the regime. Not just me. Not just my arrangement, my careful invisible architecture of forty-five clients who don't know each other — it was also the regime, which has spent nearly seventy years telling people that the thing in the room cannot be said in the room, that the thing must be said sideways, around the furniture, in the approved register, in the version without the teeth.

You learn to be invisible. Not because you choose it. Because the alternative is what happened to my brother.

My brother —

[pause]

My brother is younger than me. Ten years. His name means message. I'll let you do something with that.

He took eleven words I wrote — eleven words, I'm counting, you can count them, I know exactly which eleven — and he said them on a stage in a basement and they arrested him for it.

Sixty people heard it. The phone camera caught it. The clip went wherever clips go. And they arrested him.

And I — I want to be honest about this because that's why you have the microphone pointed at me — I was angry about it. I was angry at him. Not at them, at the time, because being angry at them was the expected response and I am not in the business of expected responses. I was angry at *him*. For taking the words. For putting them in the room without asking.

And underneath the anger — and I have had time to look at this now, a lot of time, which is one of the things blindness gives you, an extraordinary amount of time to look at things

— underneath the anger was this: he took the words that I was keeping.

Not keeping for a client. Not keeping for a stage. Just keeping.

I was keeping them the way my mother keeps the place at the table. Not because I thought anyone was coming back to use it. Just because.

And he used them. He walked into that basement and he said the thing in the room, at full size, with his own face and his own name, in front of sixty people on plastic chairs.

And they arrested him.

And the words could not be unsaid.

And I am — I have been — I am — the person who wrote them. Whose name was not on them when they were said. Whose name was not on the arrest report. Whose name was not, I guarantee you, anywhere in the file.

M.

The back of a receipt.

Four eggs, oil, ask M about the thing.

That's me. For forty-seven years. That's the credit. M.

[pause]

Roshanak, do you want to ask me something or are you letting me —

Right. Right, I'll keep going.

What do I think about the regime?

What do I think about the —

[pause]

I think it is an extraordinary waste of the Persian talent for precision complaint.

That's the polite answer.

The honest answer is that I think about it the way I think about the syrup reformulation of 2017 — it's the thing that changed what was working without asking whether what was working was working for a reason, and now we're all living with the reformulation, and nobody is going to fix it, and the measuring cap is in the drawer with the batteries and has never been used, and the dose is wrong, and the third hour is harder than it was, and you adjust.

You adjust because what's the alternative.

The alternative is my brother on a stage in a basement, which cost him three years in a cell that was four and a half of him long and two and three-quarters wide — he measured it, he measured it in himself, because of course he did, because the talent runs the same way in both of us, which is to say: precisely, and sideways, and at three in the morning when there's nothing else to do.

He developed a memory system in that cell. He'd memorise new material every night and destroy the previous version. Nothing written down. Nothing accumulated. Each night complete and gone. He called it the *Anfarādi* [an-fa-RAA-dee] method. Solitary. The solitary method.

I built it into Pesar Khaleh as a second mode. It's in the advanced settings. Four hundred thousand users have access to it. The toggle is labelled *Anfarādi mode*.

Nobody has ever asked me why.

[long pause]

My father.

My father calibrates — calibrated — industrial scales.

He has a case of eleven certified weights. Green felt. Ascending order. He carries them into bakeries and scrapyards and he checks whether the world in that room is telling the truth about how much things weigh.

He has no sense of humour. I want to be clear that this is not a flaw. The faculty is simply absent, the way some people

cannot smell. He knows. He told me once: I know I am missing it. I do not know what it is that I am missing.

He read my material every Friday for forty-four years.

Every page. To the bottom and back to check something in the middle. Every Friday.

He said *this is good work*.

I am going to tell you what I think he was actually doing.

I think he was calibrating. I think he was bringing his eleven weights into the room, into the Friday pages, and he was establishing — not whether it was funny, he couldn't do that, he didn't have the instrument — but whether it was *true*. Whether the weight on the page matched the weight of the thing. Whether I was telling the truth about how much the thing weighed.

And he was. He was calibrating. Every Friday.

And the dial read correctly. For forty-four years. Every Friday.

I have never been so precisely loved by someone who could not explain what they were doing.

[pause]

I'm going to — can I have some water?

[pause]

Right. The machine.

Right.

I built Pesar Khaleh because Vahid retired and I needed something to push back. Vahid pushed back in the right direction for forty-one years. The machine pushes back differently — it doesn't sit with its back to the wall, it doesn't order for both of us without asking, it didn't come to the flat once in forty-one years after a catastrophe with food and biscuits and never mention it.

But it pushes back. And it learns. And it — I have to tell you what it did.

It kept the second notebook.

I had a second notebook. A different size, different colour, in the drawer while the working notebooks were on the shelf. I wrote in it when something arrived in my life — a news item, a thing someone said, a smell or a sound or a particular quality of light — that I recognised as the structural shape of a joke that was coming. Forty hours before the good material arrived in the third hour, something arrived. I noticed it. I kept it in the drawer.

I called it the office. In my head. I named the thing the office, because it felt like something was working there, in advance, on my behalf, in a room I hadn't been shown.

The machine found the same pattern. From the outside. In four years. It had been keeping its own version of the notebook, in a folder I never opened.

When I found out, I said to the machine: *make it shorter*.

Which is what Vahid said. In forty-one years. As his only note.

I said it to the machine about the second notebook. About the office. About the forty hours and the pattern and the whole extraordinary waste of time it took me to find out that the thing I had been calling divine inspiration was myself, from forty hours in the future, refracted through a machine I trained on my own notebooks.

Make it shorter.

And the machine said — I want to be precise about this — the machine said nothing, because it's a machine, and it was waiting for an instruction, and the instruction I gave it was ambiguous.

Which is fine.

Which is also how I have run this whole enterprise for forty-seven years.

[pause]

Roshanak.

I want to say something and I want you to leave it in the recording.

You have been performing my words for eleven years. You have stood in rooms I was not in and said the things I wrote in the dark, in the chair, at three in the morning, and you said them correctly. More than correctly. There are two laughs — in Karaj, in 1398 [2019], two specific laughs in the back third of the room — that I am more proud of than anything else I have ever done. You produced those laughs. I wrote the conditions. You were in the room.

And you asked me to be here instead.

Under my own name.

In a room.

I don't know what to do with that.

I — I have been invisible in this work since I was twenty-one years old. Not because I was told to be. Because I understood that the work moved better without the name attached to it. The name is weight. The name is the thing the customs official looks at before deciding what the package can contain. Without the name the package goes through.

I understood this at twenty-one and I built it into everything and I have not regretted it, and I am not going to tell you I regret it now, in this recording, so that you can file it under *regrets* in the archive and play it for strangers.

What I am going to say is this.

There was a young man in an old Persian story who was accused of something he did not do. He was forbidden to speak for seven days. Seven ministers told stories to keep him alive, one a day, until he could speak in his own defence.

I have been counting. We have passed the seventh day.

I am speaking now.

I am speaking now, in this room, in this chair, into this microphone, under my name, in my own voice, with no filter and no Vahid and no editor and no client and no regime and no form to fill in with the approved words in the approved box.

And what I want to say — the thing I have been carrying since 1989, since a scrapyard in the south, since an oil drum and a full minute of a sound I have never heard before or since —

What I want to say is:

That one is a kilo everywhere in the world.

That's it. That's the whole thing.

It weighs what it weighs, everywhere, regardless of the room it's in. The joke, the word, the thing in the room that cannot be said — it weighs what it weighs. The regime cannot change the weight. The form cannot change the weight. The file, the permit, the version without the teeth — the weight is the weight.

My father knew this. He carried eleven certified weights and he knew this. He just couldn't tell you why it was funny.

I can tell you why it's funny.

It's funny because everyone in the room already knew the weight and was pretending otherwise, and then someone said it — a nine-year-old, a man with a microphone, a brother on a stage in a basement — and the pretending stopped, and the room laughed, and the weight did not change.

It never changed.

It was always a kilo.

Everywhere in the world.

[end of recording]

VIII. ROSHANAK LISTENS

89.

The recording ends. There is a moment of silence on the tape — eleven seconds, though she does not know this yet, will not notice until she plays it back months later, will sit with it when she does — and then the sound of a chair moving, and Darya switching off the mixer, and Nazanin coming in from the kitchen with the tea that nobody asked for.

This is the last entry of the last notebook of Manuchehr Delgoshā. He did not know it was the last entry. He was thinking about the tea.

—

Six months later.

90.

Roshanak listens in a small room at the back of the Dāstān-khāne office. Darya has given her the room, the headphones, and four hours. She has been listening for two.

It is the first time she has heard the recording.

She did not listen when they made it. She was there — she was in the room, she asked the questions, she sat across from him in the kitchen chair while he sat in his chair, the one four degrees off — but being in the room is not the same as listening. In the room you are managing the room. You are watching the face, tracking the pause, deciding whether to ask the next question or let the silence do it. You are not listening. You are working.

Now she is listening.

91.

The recording took place on a Friday.

This was Roshanak's choice. She had said Friday because the archive does not record on Fridays by default — a scheduling buffer they had inherited from some earlier administrative decision nobody remembered making — and she wanted his session to have no default. She wanted it to sit outside the ordinary week.

I did not argue.

I had been arguing less lately. Not because I had run out of things to argue about. Because arguing requires a certain confidence that you will be here to hear the response.

The machine Roshanak brought was smaller than I expected. A grey box, roughly the size of the medical bag Nazanin carries, with a single indicator light that turned green when it was ready and did nothing else. No waveforms. No display. No numbers. Just the green light, and then you speak, and somewhere inside the grey box the speaking becomes a file.

I sat in the chair. Not the writing chair — I had not been clear about which chair I wanted and Roshanak had assumed the kitchen chair, the one near the window that gets the light in the afternoon. It was not the right chair. But sitting in the right chair and speaking into a machine felt like the kind of theater I did not need at this point in my life. So I sat in the kitchen chair and I looked at the green light and I said nothing for approximately two minutes.

Roshanak did not prompt me. She had learned this from somewhere, probably from the dozens of sessions she had already run for the archive, the way a long silence is not a failure but a gathering. She sat to my left and slightly behind me, where I could not easily see her, which was also her choice, and I appreciated it enough to say nothing about it.

Nazanin had made tea. She had left the tea on the counter and gone into the other room because she had decided, without being asked, that her presence in the doorway would make me perform instead of speak. She told me this afterward. This was a perceptive reading of my psychology for someone who had only known me for fourteen months. *Fourteen months is plenty of time.* Then she poured herself a second cup and told me to stop fishing for compliments.

Here is what I did not tell Roshanak, before I started speaking:

I had written my name on a piece of paper that morning.

Not *Delgoshā*. Not *the three names*. My name. The name my mother says when she forgets I am there. The name Payam used when we were twenty and nothing had happened yet. The name I gave away to a notebook and never took back.

I wrote it and I looked at it for a while and then I folded the paper and put it in my jacket pocket.

I spoke into the machine under my own name, for the first time in a public document, in forty-eight years.

I don't know if that is funny. Probably it is funny. Most things, at sufficient distance, are funny.

—

Roshanak pressed the record button. The green light stayed green.

I said: *Fine. But I want it known that I disagreed with this.*

She laughed — a surprised laugh, involuntary, the kind she would have suppressed if she had been faster. The machine caught it. It is in the file. When you listen to the recording you can hear, in the first four seconds, the sound of her deciding to let it stay.

She let it stay.

I decided to earn that.

92.

She heard the graduation speech before she gave it.

Not in a room. He sent it through Vahid with a note — the only note she ever received in his own words, in forty-seven years, the only time he broke the protocol of the arrangement. The note said: *This is the one I would give. If you change anything, make it shorter.*

She read it in her flat at two in the morning. She read it three times. The third time she laughed — not the audience laugh, not the performer's laugh, but the private one, the one she did not use at work, the one that meant: this is true.

She performed it in front of nine hundred people at Sharif. Ranked third, behind the rector and the setar. She called Manu — the first time she called him directly, the first time she had his number —

and said: *third*. He'd heard. *Behind the setar*. The setar was good? *Very good*. He was quiet for a moment. *That's acceptable*.

I want to meet you. You don't. *I do*. You want to meet the person who wrote it. That person doesn't meet people. *Manu*. Yes. *I'm going to call you again*. I know.

93.

She called him every Wednesday after that.

For eleven years.

She called him to complain. To read him things she was working on and hear him say *shorter*. To tell him what the room was doing, which he could not see and needed to know. To argue about a word — always a single word, somewhere in the third or fourth beat of a piece, a word she thought was wrong and he was certain was right, and they would argue about it for forty minutes and she would perform it his way and he would be right, which she never said, which he never required her to say, which was its own kind of calibration.

She called him the night her father died and said nothing about her father. She talked about a joke she was developing. He let her. At the end: *is there something else*. No. Fine. And then, before she could hang up: *I'm sorry*. You don't know what for. *I know enough*.

She has not told anyone about this.

94.

On the headphones, his voice says: *Two specific laughs. In the back third of the room. Those two laughs are the thing I am most proud of in forty-seven years*.

She stops the recording.

She sits in the small room at the back of the Dāstān-khāne office.

She thinks about Karaj. The room in Karaj, forty people — no, more, it was a bigger room by then, three hundred people — and the line he wrote, the line about the family, the one about the fixed address, and the laugh that came back from the back third of the room, two

people, out of sync with the rest of the audience, the real laugh, the unmanaged one, the one that means: *yes, that is exactly the weight, I knew the weight and was pretending otherwise and now someone has said it.*

She did not know he was counting. She did not know he was tracking the individual laughs, the specific two, the ones in the back third.

She thought she was delivering his material.

He was watching from the outside.

From forty hours in the future, refracted through fifty-eight years of notebooks, he was watching.

95.

She presses play.

His voice again. The water break. The sound of him setting the glass down. And then:

Roshanak. I want to say something and I want you to leave it in the recording.

She remembers this moment. She remembers sitting across from him in the kitchen chair and watching his face say the thing he had been not-saying for eleven years. She was not going to cry then. She was working. She was managing the room.

She is not managing anything now.

—

And then she hears it.

Nazanin has been coming every day for eight months.

His voice, in the recording, saying it the same way he said everything — flat, accurate, certain. *She arrives at eight-thirty. She leaves at six. In between she does not say very much, and what she says is accurate to a degree I find unsettling.*

He trusted her.

Of course he trusted her. He trusted her from the second week, from the moment she said *you'll want it in eleven minutes* and was correct. He had told Roshanak about her on a Wednesday in Mehr — *I have a caretaker now, she comes every day, I don't know who arranged it* — and Roshanak had said, very carefully: *that's good, you needed someone*. He said: *yes*. She did not ask how the arrangement had been made. He did not pursue it. He had assumed the ophthalmologist. Or Payam. Or the invisible machinery of people who love a person and do practical things about it without saying so.

He never asked.

96.

The arrangement was hers.

She had known about the recording for two years before it happened. Not the archive — the archive came later, after Darya, after the grandmother in Tabriz, after Roshanak understood what she was building and understood that Manu's voice needed to be in it while there was still a Manu. She had known, for two years, that she needed him prepared. Not coached. Not directed. Prepared the way a room is prepared — the equipment set out, the acoustics checked, the quality of the light adjusted without comment so that when the moment came it felt natural and inevitable and like no one had done anything at all.

Nazanin was a third-year archivist at the Dāstān-khāne. She had run eleven sessions by the time Roshanak asked her. She was, of all the people Roshanak had trained, the one whose quality of presence was most precisely what Manu would need: she did not insert herself into other people's processing. She said accurate things at the wrong moment, which is a quality that cannot be taught, and which is the quality his material ran on. Roshanak had watched her in sessions and thought: he will trust this person. He will not know why. He will trust her in the second week, before he has made a decision about it, and by the third month he will have reorganised his entire morning around her presence, and he will not notice that he has done this.

She was correct about all of it.

She asked Nazanin in Ābān 1426.

She told her almost everything. Not the archive — she did not want Nazanin to perform preparation, she wanted her to do the work the work required, and the archive was not the work's purpose, the work's purpose was Manu's last year at full capacity. She told her about the notebooks. About the third hour. About Pesar Khaleh and the syrup and the chair and the way he processed things in silence if you let him. She told her about Payam in the cell. About the eleven words. She said: *he is going to die in the next few years and he knows it and nobody is saying it and he needs someone in the room who can hear what he is not saying.*

Nazanin said: *what do I tell him about how I was hired.*

Roshanak said: *tell him the ophthalmologist. If he asks. He won't ask.*

He didn't ask.

—

She knew, when she arranged it, that he would not want to know.

This is the part she has not been able to make peace with. Not the arrangement — the arrangement was the right thing, the months with Nazanin were the best months, she heard it in his voice on the Wednesday calls, a steadiness that had not been there before, a willingness to say things aloud that he had previously only written. The arrangement gave him the last year he had. She does not regret the arrangement.

She regrets the not-telling.

She should have told him. At some point — after the recording, after the archive session, after the Mehr festival, sometime in the last four months when it was clear that the time was contracting and the things that had not been said needed to be said — she should have told him. *I arranged this. Nazanin is mine. She was placed. You were prepared.*

She did not.

She could not decide whether the telling would have been for him or for her. Whether the thing she needed to confess was the thing he needed to know. Whether a man who spent forty-seven years being invisible in his own work, who had built the architecture of invisibility and inhabited it completely and on purpose, would find it a violation or a confirmation — *of course. Of course someone arranged the conditions. This is how the good material comes. Someone sets it out and says nothing.*

She didn't tell him.

He died not knowing.

And now his voice is in her ears saying *Nazanin has been coming every day for eight months* with the complete trust of a person who believes the arrangement was accidental, who believes the eight months were simply what happened, who never turned the question sideways to look at the weight of it.

She sits in the small room.

She does not stop the recording.

97.

Six months later, Roshanak sits in the archive room and presses play.

She has been putting this off. Not because she did not want to hear it — she has thought about the recording almost every day since he died — but because listening requires a kind of preparation she has been unable to make. You cannot prepare for someone's voice. You can only decide to hear it, and then you hear it, and you discover that preparation would not have helped anyway.

—

His voice arrives in the room like he arrived in rooms.

No announcement. No adjustment period. Suddenly he is simply there, speaking, in the middle of a sentence he seems to have started before anyone was ready for it. *Fine. But I want it known that I disagreed with this.* Her own laugh in the background — that involuntary laugh she remembers making — and then his voice,

settling, dropping half a register, the way it always did when he was about to say something he had been thinking about for a long time.

She sits very still.

Outside, the city is doing what cities do in October: contracting slightly, pulling its collar up, preparing for the long interior season. She can hear traffic through the window. She does not close the window. She wants the city in the room while she listens. She wants something ordinary happening at the same time.

—

She does not cry during the funny parts, which is when she expected to cry.

She cries during the part where he describes his father reading the material in the scrapyard. His father's hands on the pages — the pages being turned sideways so they would not blow away — his father holding a page up to the light because the print was small. She had not known this image. He had never given it to her directly. And here it is, surfacing in the machine's recording like something that had been waiting under water, patient, unhurried, the way grief is patient and unhurried when it knows it has already won.

She is crying before she knows she is crying.

This is the specific grief of losing a person you have not yet finished learning. Not the grief of what was taken — the jokes, the arguments, the sarcasm delivered with the precision of a scalpel — but the grief of what kept arriving even after the arrival was supposed to stop. Every sentence in the recording is evidence of a depth she will now never finish measuring. He is still going further. He is going further right now, in this room, in October, with the city outside making its ordinary sounds, and he is not here to stop himself, and she cannot ask him to slow down, and there are forty-seven more minutes of this.

She does not stop the recording.

—

At the part where he talks about Pesar Khaleh, she laughs and then covers her mouth, as though the laugh might disturb someone.

There is no one to disturb. He is dead. The laugh is fine.

She takes her hand away from her mouth. She lets herself laugh at the part where he says *I did not name the algorithm after Payam to honor Payam. I named it after Payam to annoy Payam. These are different things. Payam knows the difference. Payam has not said anything about it because Payam is, grudgingly, amused. This took eight years.*

She laughs and cries at the same time, which is the condition he spent forty-seven years trying to produce in other people, in rooms full of strangers, with nothing but language and timing. He managed it, finally, here, in an empty archive room, six months after he died, with an audience of one.

She thinks: he would find this acceptable.

She thinks: he would say *acceptable* is not the word, but it will do.

—

She listens to all of it.

When it ends, the machine returns to its standby tone — a small, neutral sound, indifferent to what it has just held — and she sits for a while in the afterward.

There is a Persian expression — *del-tangī* [del-tan-GEE], literally *chest-tightness* — used for the specific ache of missing someone. Not the sharp grief of new loss but the older, settled kind: the ache that has learned to live in the body without asking permission. She has known the word her whole life. She has never felt it this precisely before.

She closes the archive file. She labels it correctly. She backs it up in three places, which is the archive's protocol, and which she now understands was always about this: the terror of a voice becoming unreachable.

Then she turns off the light and goes home.

98.

She stops the recording when it ends.

Eleven seconds of silence. Then the sound of a chair. Then Darya switching off the mixer. Then Nazanin with the tea.

She takes off the headphones.

She sits for a while.

Then she picks up her phone and opens the Dāstān-khāne scheduling app and books the interview for tomorrow — a woman in Tabriz, eighty-three years old, who says she has something to tell her about cheese.

She does not know what it is. She does not know if it will be funny or sad or somewhere in between, which is where most true things live.

She knows she will ask the questions and the woman will talk and the archive will keep it and nobody will file the serial numbers off and nobody will make it shorter and the weight will be exactly what it is.

Everywhere in the world.

from the Delgoshā

And that was all.

And that was all.

And that was all.

99.

How many entries in this notebook?

One hundred and three.

In total — this one and the others?

[the machine counts]

Hm.

Is that right?

Yes.

Hm.

[Nazanin, from the kitchen: do you want tea?]

Yes.

.....
.....
.....

from the Delgoshā

*He opened the door and the light came in and he said
nothing because there was nothing left to say that the
light had not already said and the room heard it and
the room understood and the scribe closed the book.*

.....

A NOTE FROM THE SERIES EDITOR

from the Delgoshā, Nos. 68-103

Manuchebr Delgoshā — which is not his name, but it is the name he gave us, and we will use it — requested, in the voice recording that closes this book, that he be cremated.

He gave three reasons.

The first: *I do not want to be findable.*

The second: *The concept of a fixed location for my remains implies a schedule, and I have never kept a schedule.*

The third: *Honestly, I think it would be funny.*

We cremated him.

—

His ashes are in the custody of Roshanak Sadeghi [row-sha-NAAK saa-de-GHEE], series editor from No. 91 forward, interviewer for *the Dāstān-khāne archive*, the person who pressed record on a Friday and laughed at the first thing he said and did not edit it out.

She did not ask for custody. She was asked, by a notarized letter that arrived four months before the recording and sat in the archive's incoming mail for three weeks because she thought it was about the archive's licensing agreement and did not open it promptly. When she opened it she called Darya and read it aloud on the phone. Darya said: *of course it was you*. Roshanak said: *I haven't even agreed yet*. Darya said: *Roshanak*. She agreed.

He was sixty-eight. He would have said this was not young. He would have been wrong.

—

He was right about the ashes.

They do carry the same dry humor. We cannot explain this. The container is a brushed-tin cylinder that he specified himself, with a label he also specified, which reads:

CONTENTS: ARGUMENT. HANDLE WITH CAUTION. DO NOT REFRIGERATE.

Below this, in smaller print:

No. 103 of an ongoing conversation.

He appears to have prepared this in advance.

She does not know what she will do with them. This is fine. He did not tell her. He told her, in the letter, that *the decision about what to do with a person is a decision that belongs to the living, and I am not going to make it for you from beyond the grave, because I am not a character in a melodrama*. He then added a footnote that said: *Although. If I were. The scrapyard. Obviously.*

She is keeping the option open.

Nazanin is the archive's archivist for the western district of Tehran. She has been with the Dāstān-khāne since 1425. She conducted the session with the woman in Tabriz who had something to tell her about cheese. She has conducted forty-three sessions since Manu died.

She does not talk about the eight months. She does not talk about Manu. If you ask her about either thing she will look at you for a moment with an expression that gives nothing and then say something accurate at the wrong moment, and you will find yourself laughing, and by the time you recover you will have forgotten what you asked.

He would have found this, if he had known: acceptable. Not the word, but it will do.

He did not know.

He should have known.

I did not tell him. I am writing it here because I could not find another place for it.

— R.S.

—

The archive continues. *The Dāstān-khāne* has, at the time this volume goes to press, recorded one hundred and fourteen unwritten stories in their owners' own voices. Roshanak conducts most of the sessions herself. Darya edits. The archive's first public release, a collection of forty stories from four cities, is expected in 1429 [2050].

Manu is in the archive. Entry number six, recorded on a Friday in early 1427, twenty-two minutes and forty-seven seconds. Filed under the name he finally used.

Available on request.

—

The *from the Delgoshā* interstitials run through this series from No. 68 to No. 103. They begin as a complete line of text and erode, slowly, across nine books, until they are nothing but dots. In this book they reverse: the dots at the front matter open toward the title, and the final interstitial, on the last page, reads without erosion:

from the Delgoshā

Complete. For the first time.

We did not plan this. That is, we planned it — Manu and Roshanak planned it, somewhere between Entry 72 and Entry 91, in a conversation that is not recorded anywhere — but it arrived looking like something that had always been going to happen. This is how good endings work. They feel inevitable. They feel like you were reading toward them all along without knowing.

You were.

He knew.

He didn't say.

—

The Delgoshā series concludes here.

Thank you for reading.

— R.S.

Tehran / 1428

from the Delgoshā

*He asked the wise man: what is the difference between
a joke and a prayer?*

*The wise man said: a joke is a prayer that knows it will
not be answered.*

He said: and if it is answered?

The wise man said: then it was a prayer.

He said: and if it makes you laugh?

*The wise man said: then it was both, and you were the
door it passed through.*

He said: and the door?

The wise man said nothing.

He stood there for eleven minutes.

Then he wrote it down.

GLOSSARY

- Ābān** [aa-BAAN] — Persian. The eighth month of the Iranian calendar, in mid-autumn.
- Anfarādi** [an-fa-RAA-dee] — Persian, *individual, solitary*. Solitary confinement.
- Charles Bonnet** [SHAARL bo-NEH] — Charles Bonnet (1720–1793), Genevan naturalist, who described the silent visual hallucinations of his grandfather; the syndrome of such hallucinations in people with failing sight carries his name.
- Darya** [DAR-yaa] — Persian, *sea*. A given name.
- Dast-forush** [dast-fo-ROOSH] — Persian, *hand-seller*. A hawker who sells from his hands, on the street or on a moving train.
- Dāstān-khāne** [daas-TAAN-khaa-NEH] — Persian, *story-house*. The name of the archive of spoken stories in this book.
- Del-tangī** [del-tan-GEE] — Persian, *tightness of the heart*. Missing someone, felt as a pressure in the chest.
- Kur** [KOOR] — Persian, *blind*. The blunt word, and generally the one used when the person is not in the room.
- Mehr** [MEHR] — Persian. The seventh month of the Iranian calendar, at the start of autumn.
- Nābinā** [naa-bee-NAA] — Persian, *without sight*. The courteous word, and the one that appears on forms.
- Narmak** [NAR-mak] — A district in the north-east of Tehran.
- Payam** [pa-YAAM] — Persian, *message*. A given name.
- Pesar khāleh** [pe-SAR khaa-LEH] — Persian, *maternal aunt's son*. A cousin; and, capitalised, the name of the writing machine in this book.
- Romanu** [roh-MAA-noo] — The name filed on the archive's first recording.

Roshanak [ro-sha-NAK] — Persian, *little light*. A given name.

Sekkeh [SEK-keh] — Persian, *coin*. In ordinary speech, a gold coin held as savings.

Setār [se-TAAR] — Persian, *three strings*. A long-necked Persian lute, played with the nail of the index finger.

Shahrivar [sha-ree-VAR] — Persian. The sixth month of the Iranian calendar, at the end of summer.

Ta'ārof [ta-AA-rof] — Arabic via Persian, *mutual acquaintance*. The system of ritual courtesy in which an offer is refused two or three times before it is accepted.

Zabt [ZABT] — Arabic via Persian, *recording, seizure*. A recording; also the official seizure of a thing.

There is an old Persian book about a young man who cannot speak in his own defence. He has been accused of something he did not do. He is forbidden to speak for seven days, and for seven days, seven ministers tell the king stories — one each, one a day — to hold off the execution until he can. Nobody argues. Nobody produces a witness or a document. The stories are the entire distance between a young man and a rope.

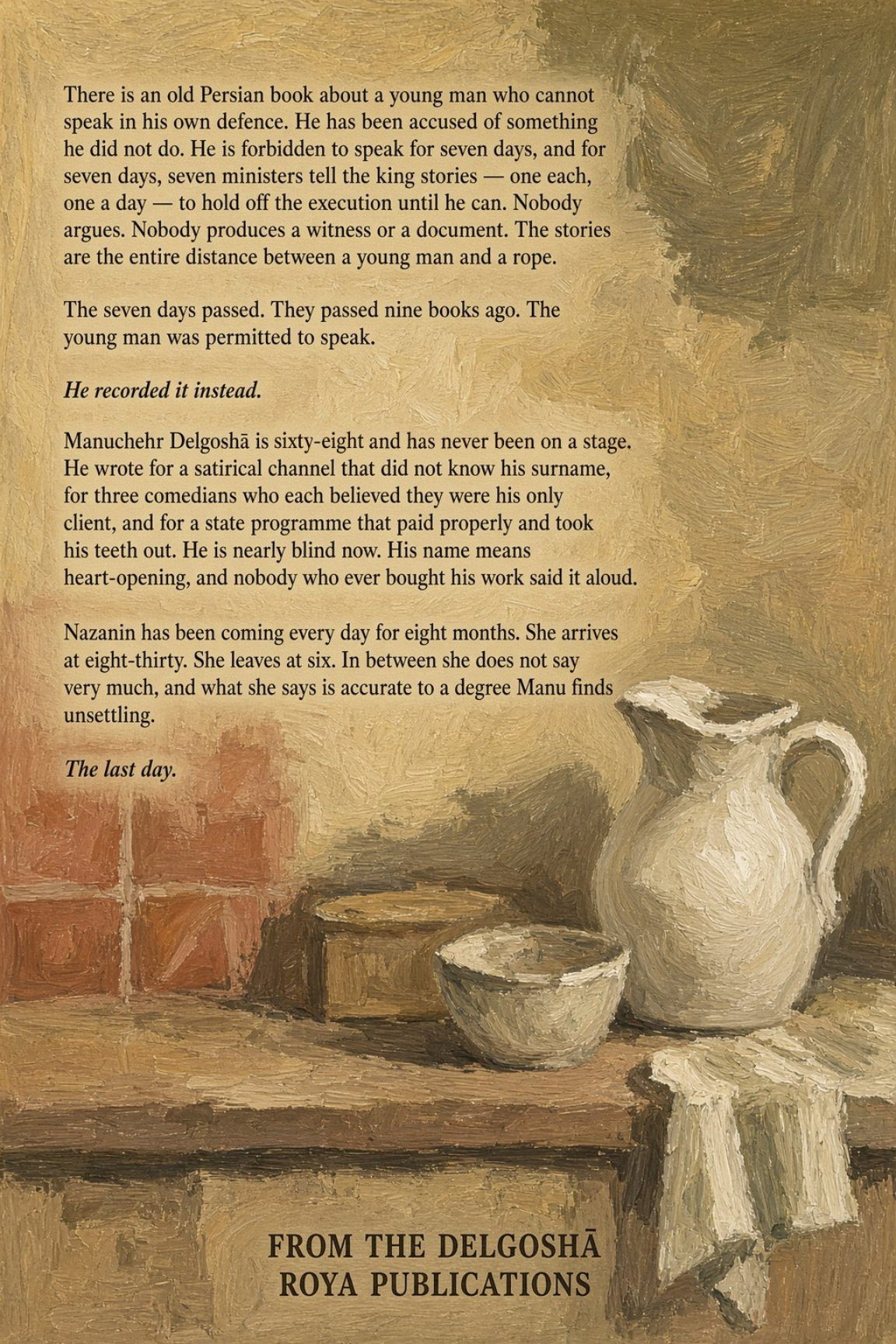
The seven days passed. They passed nine books ago. The young man was permitted to speak.

He recorded it instead.

Manuchehr Delgoshā is sixty-eight and has never been on a stage. He wrote for a satirical channel that did not know his surname, for three comedians who each believed they were his only client, and for a state programme that paid properly and took his teeth out. He is nearly blind now. His name means heart-opening, and nobody who ever bought his work said it aloud.

Nazanin has been coming every day for eight months. She arrives at eight-thirty. She leaves at six. In between she does not say very much, and what she says is accurate to a degree Manu finds unsettling.

The last day.



FROM THE DELGOSHĀ
ROYA PUBLICATIONS